

Tinctures

Tinctures are made by soaking an herb in alcohol. This encourages the active plant constituents to dissolve, giving tinctures a relatively stronger action than infusions or decoctions. They are convenient to use and last up to two years. Tinctures can be made using a jug and a jelly bag, instead of a wine press. Although mainly used in European, American, and Australian herbal medicine, tinctures play a part in most herbal traditions.

Tinctures are strong preparations, and it is essential to check the recommended dosage. Never use industrial alcohol, methylated spirits (methyl alcohol) or rubbing alcohol (isopropyl alcohol) in tinctures.

Alcohol-reduced Tinctures

Alcoholic tinctures should sometimes be avoided, for example during pregnancy or a gastric inflammation. Adding 1 tsp (5 ml) of tincture to a small glass of almost boiling water and leaving it for 5 minutes allows the alcohol to evaporate. To make nonalcoholic tinctures, replace the alcohol with vinegar or glycerol.

Tincture Ratios

Tinctures are made in different strengths, expressed as ratios. In this book, a 1:5 ratio (1 part herb to 5 parts alcohol) is used, unless otherwise stated.



2 Set up the wine press, placing a muslin or nylon mesh bag securely inside. Pour in the mixture and collect the liquid in the jug.



1 Place the herb in a large, clean glass jar and pour on the alcohol, ensuring that the herb is covered. Close and label the jar. Shake well for 1–2 minutes and store in a cool dark place for 10–14 days, shaking the jar every 1–2 days.



3 Slowly close the wine press, extracting the remaining liquid from the herbs until no more drips appear. Discard the leftover herbs.

Standard Quantity

200 g dried or 300 g fresh herb chopped into small pieces to 1 quart (1 liter) alcohol—vodka of 35–40% alcohol is ideal, although rum hides the taste of bitter or unpalatable herbs

Standard Dosage

Take 1 tsp (5 ml) 2–3 times a day diluted in 1 tbsp plus 1 tsp (25 ml) of water or fruit juice.

Storage

Store in sterilized, dark glass bottles in a cool dark place for up to 2 years.



4 Pour the tincture into clean, dark glass bottles using a funnel. When full, stopper with a cork or screw top and label the bottles.

Capsules & Powders

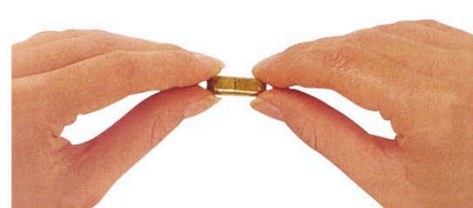
Powdered herbs are most easily taken as capsules but can be sprinkled on food or taken with water. Externally, they can be applied as a dusting powder to the skin or mixed with tinctures as a poultice (see p. 295).

Reputable herbal suppliers are the best place to buy powdered herbs and, in general, the finer the powder the better the grade and quality. Gelatin or vegetarian capsule cases are also available from specialist outlets. Powdered slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145) makes a useful base for poultices (see p. 295), and astringents such as witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102) may be applied to weeping skin or mixed into ointments (see p. 295) for hemorrhoids and varicose veins.

Making Capsules



1 Pour the powder into a saucer and slide the capsule halves toward one another, scooping up the powder (or use a capsule-making tray).



2 When the halves of the capsule are full of powder, slide them together without spilling the powder, and store.

Standard Quantity

Fill size 00 capsules, which contain approximately 250 mg of powdered herb

Standard Dosage

Take 2–3 capsules twice a day.

Storage

Store in airtight, dark glass containers in a cool place for up to 3–4 months.